

Promises and Pressure: Outside Pressure

承诺与压力：外部压力

Theme: 友谊、家庭与人际关系 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

English Story

The external pressure came as a **detailed** report from the city. One member of the committee, a **very** **attentive** woman, wrote that the project had been **neglectful** of its own staff. "You cannot **continue** like this," she said. "The number of unpaid hours is a scandal, not a virtue."

The **accusation** was partly fair. **Behind** the **small** office, an **elderly** **diner** kept a ledger of every hour they had worked, and the total was a **challenge** to their own honesty. "We are in a **siege** of our own making," Maya said. "Since the report has been filed, all we can do is answer it."

A **champion** of the project, a **communicative** woman with a **possessive** streak, proposed a **fight**: **raise** the fee, **commit** the council, and let the **quarrel** become public. "That is a **provocative** move," Lin said. "It is also a **slippery one**. **Haste** would **dampen** the **very** thing we are trying to prove."

The **moderate** path was harder than the **visionary one**. It meant a **cubic** metre of space instead of an office, a **part-time** electrician instead of a team, an **electric** kettle instead of a kitchen, and a **moderate** fee for the volunteers. "We must not **neglect** the **needy member** of this group," she said, "and we must not **rub** salt into the wound either."

The **sitting** ended with a compromise and a **maiden** speech from the youngest volunteer. "**Diligence** is not the same as obedience," she said, "and a **feverish** week is not a plan." The **ball** was in the council's court; she **really** did **threaten** to resign, and the **affectionate** letter that followed did not change the **dimensional** **cast** of the problem: a **contest** between a **prison** of **small** habits and a situated, human schedule. The **squeeze** was on the budget, not on her patience, and the question was whether the **electric** bill counted as a **part** of the project's true **dimension**. She wrote that sentence twice, and then a third time, because a **dimension** she could not name was exactly the thing that had defeated them in March. They had committed themselves to a smaller scope and a clearer **scenery** of responsibility. "Than the last one," Lin added, "which is to say: **better**, when you can tell the difference."

中文翻译

外部压力以一份来自市里的详尽报告到来。委员会里一位非常留心的女士写道，这个项目一直忽视自己的工作人员。“你们不能这样继续下去，”她说，“无偿工时的数字是一桩丑闻，不是美德。”

这项指控有一部分是公正的。在小办公室后面，一位年长的用餐者保存着一本记录他们每一小时工作的账本，总数是对他们自己诚实的挑战。“我们处在一场自己造成的围困中，”曼雅说，“既然报告已经提交，我们能做的就是回应它。”

项目的一位拥护者，一位爱交际、带点占有欲的女士，提议打一仗：提高费用、让议会承诺、让争吵公开化。“那是一步挑衅性的棋，”林伟说，“也是一步很滑的棋。匆忙会浇灭我们正想证明的东西。”

温和的道路比幻想式的道路更难走。它意味着一立方米的房间而不是一间办公室，一位兼职电工而不是一个团队，以及给志愿者一份适度的报酬。“我们既不能忽视这个群体里贫困的成员，”她说，“也不能往伤口上撒盐。”

会议以一项妥协和那位最年轻志愿者的首次发言结束。“勤奋不等同于服从，”她说，“而发烧般的一周不是计划。”球在议会那一边；她确实威胁过辞职，而随后那封深情的信并没有改变问题的维度结构：这是一场小习惯的监狱与一个被妥善安置的、有人情味的时间表之间的竞赛。被压缩的是预算，不是她的耐心；而问题在于，电费算不算这个项目真正维度的一部分。她把这句话写了两遍，然后又写了第三遍，因为一个她叫不出名字的维度，正是三月里击败他们的那样东西。他们承诺了更小的范围与更清晰的职责图景。“比上一份好，”林伟补充说，“也就是说：更好——前提是你分辨差别。”

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
part pɑ:t POS: n	n. 部分, 局部, 零件, 要素, 等分, 职责, 角色, 部位; vt. 分开, 分离, 断绝, 区别, 分配; vi. 分开, 断裂, ... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. something determined in relation to something that includes it; n. something less than the whole of a human...
continue kən'tɪnju: POS: vi	vi. 继续, 延续, 延长; vt. 使继续, 使延长 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. continue a certain state, condition, or activity; v. continue talking; v. keep or maintain in unaltered cond...
behind bi'haind POS: adv	adv. 在后地; prep. 在...背后 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. having the lower score or lagging position in a contest; r. in or to or toward the rear; r. remaining in a p...
raise reiz POS: n	n. 上升, 高地, 增高; vt. 升起, 举起, 唤起, 提高, 使出现, 使复活, 提出, 筹集, 饲养 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the amount a salary is increased; n. increasing the size of a bet (as in poker); v. raise the level or amoun...
better 'betə POS: a	a. 较好的; adv. 比较好 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. something superior in quality or condition or effect; n. a superior person having claim to precedence; n. th...
fight fait POS: n	n. 打架, 争吵, 斗志; v. 对抗, 打架 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of fighting; any contest or struggle; n. an intense verbal dispute; n. a boxing or wrestling match; v...
ball bɔ:l POS: n	n. 球, 舞会, 球状物; v. 捏成球形 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. round object that is hit or thrown or kicked in games; n. an object with a spherical shape; n. the people as...
challenge 'tʃælɪndʒ POS: n	n. 挑战, 盘问; vt. 向...挑战, 要求, 怀疑; vi. 挑战, 对(证据等)表示异议 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a demanding or stimulating situation; n. a call to engage in a contest or fight; n. questioning a statement...
prison 'prɪzn POS: n	n. 监狱, 监禁, 拘留所; vt. 监禁 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a correctional institution where persons are confined while on trial or for punishment; n. a prisonlike sit...
threaten 'θreɪn POS: vt	vt. 恐吓, 威胁, 预示...的凶兆; vi. 威胁, 恫吓, 可能来临 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. to utter intentions of injury or punishment against: "He threatened me when I tried to call the police"; v. ...
commit kə'mɪt POS: vt	vt. 委托(托付), 犯罪, 指派...作战, 使承担义务; [法] 犯, 做, 把...交给 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. cause to be admitted; of persons to an institution; v. engage in or perform
detailed 'di:teɪld POS: a	a. 详细的, 复杂的; [法] 详细的, 详尽的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. developed or executed with care and in minute detail
elderly 'eldəli POS: a	a. 过了中年的, 稍老的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n people who are old collectively; s advanced in years; ('aged' is pronounced as two syllables)
champion 'tʃæmpɪən POS: n	n. 冠军, 拥护者, 战士; vt. 保卫, 拥护; a. 优胜的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who has won first place in a competition; n. someone who fights for a cause; v. protect or fight for...
cast kɑ:st. kæst POS: n	n. 演员阵容, 投掷, 铸件, 预测, 特性; vt. 投, 掷, 抛, 脱落, 铸, 使弯曲, 计算; vi. 投, 计算, 浇铸成型 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the actors in a play; n. the distinctive form in which a thing is made; n. bandage consisting of a firm cove...
dimension daɪ'menʃən POS: n	n. 尺寸, 次元, 面积, 维数; vt. 标出尺寸 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the magnitude of something in a particular direction (especially length or width or height); n. one of thre...
electric ɪ'lektɪk POS: a	a. 电的, 导电的, 电动的; [医] 电的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a car that is powered by electricity; a. using or providing or producing or transmitting or operated by ele...
rub rʌb POS: n	n. 摩擦, 困难, 障碍, 磨损处; vt. 擦, 搓, 摩擦, 惹怒; vi. 摩擦, 擦破 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of rubbing or wiping; v. move over something with pressure; v. cause friction; v. scrape or rub as if...
squeeze skwi:z POS: n	n. 紧握, 挤, 榨, 榨取, 佣金; vt. 紧握, 挤, 榨取; vi. 压榨, 榨 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of gripping and pressing firmly; n. a situation in which increased costs cannot be passed on to the...
contest 'kɒntest POS: n	n. 竞赛, 争论; vt. 竞争, 争取, 争辩; vi. 竞争 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an occasion on which a winner is selected from among two or more contestants; n. a struggle between rivals; ...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
moderate 'mɒdəreɪt POS: a	a. 适度的, 稳健的, 中等的, 节制的; vt. 节制, 减轻, 使缓和; vi. 变缓和, 主持会议 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. preside over; v. make less fast or intense; a. being within reasonable or average limits; not excessive or e...
situate 'sitʃueɪt POS: vt	vt. 使位于, 使处于 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. determine or indicate the place, site, or limits of, as if by an instrument or by a survey; v. put (somethi...
neglect ni'glekt POS: n	n. 疏忽, 忽略, 漏做; vt. 疏忽, 忽视, 不顾 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the state of something that has been unused and neglected; v. leave undone or leave out; v. fail to attend t...
accusation ækju:'zeɪʃən POS: n	n. 控告, 指控, 指责; [法] 控告, 起诉, 告发 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a formal charge of wrongdoing brought against a person; the act of imputing blame or guilt; n. an assertion...
sitting 'sɪtɪŋ POS: n	n. 入席, 就坐, 开庭, 孵卵; a. 坐着的, 就座的, 在职的, 在孵卵中的, 易被击中的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (photography) the act of assuming a certain position (as for a photograph or portrait); n. the act of assum...
diner 'daɪneɪ POS: n	n. 用餐者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person eating a meal (especially in a restaurant); n. a restaurant that resembles a dining car
siege si:dʒ POS: n	n. 包围, 围攻, 再三的努力; vt. 包围, 围攻 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the action of an armed force that surrounds a fortified place and isolates it while continuing to attack
scenery 'si:nəri POS: n	n. 风景, 景色, 舞台布景 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the painted structures of a stage set that are intended to suggest a particular locale; n. the appearance o...
provocative prə'vɒkətɪv POS: a	a. 激发感情的, 挑拨的, 刺激的; n. 刺激物, 挑拨物, 兴奋剂 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. serving or tending to provoke, excite, or stimulate; stimulating discussion or exciting controversy; s. exc...
slippery 'slɪpəri POS: a	a. 滑的, 光滑的, 靠不住的, 圆滑的, 不稳固的; [法] 狡猾的, 不可靠的, 不安定的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. causing or tending to cause things to slip or slide; s. not to be trusted
quarrel 'kwɒrəl POS: n	n. 吵架, 反目, 怨言, 方头凿; vi. 吵架, 争论, 挑剔 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an angry dispute; n. an arrow that is shot from a crossbow; has a head with four edges; v. have a disagreeme...
cubic 'kju:bɪk POS: a	a. 立方体的, 立方的; [机] 立方的, 立方体的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. having three dimensions
needy 'ni:di POS: a	a. 贫穷的, 贫困的, 生活艰苦的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. needy people collectively; s. demanding or needing attention, affection, or reassurance to an excessive deg...
visionary 'vɪʒənəri POS: a	a. 幻像的, 幻想的, 梦想的; n. 有眼力的人, 空想家, 梦想者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person given to fanciful speculations and enthusiasms with little regard for what is actually possible; n...
communicative kə'mju:nikeɪtɪv POS: a	a. 健谈的, 爱说话的, 交际的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to communication; a. able or tending to communicate
attentive ə'tentɪv POS: a	a. 注意的, 留心的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. (often followed by 'to') giving care or attention
haste heɪst POS: n	n. 匆忙, 急忙 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. overly eager speed (and possible carelessness); n. the act of moving hurriedly and in a careless manner
dampen 'dæmpən POS: vt	vt. 弄湿, 使沮丧; vi. 变湿, 丧气 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. reduce the amplitude (of oscillations or waves); v. make vague or obscure or make (an image) less visible; v...
affectionate ə'fekʃənət POS: a	a. 深情的, 充满情爱的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. having or displaying warmth or affection
maiden 'meɪdn POS: n	n. 年轻未婚女子, 少女, 处女; a. 未婚的, 处女的, 初次的, 无经验的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n an unmarried girl (especially a virgin); n (cricket) an over in which no runs are scored; s serving to set in...
diligence 'dɪlɪdʒəns POS: n	n. 勤奋 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. conscientiousness in paying proper attention to a task; giving the degree of care required in a given situ...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
feverish 'fi:vəriʃ POS: a	a. 发热的, 极度兴奋的, 不安的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. marked by intense agitation or emotion; s. having or affected by a fever
dimensional daɪ'menʃənəl POS: a	a. ...维的; [化] 量纲的; 因次的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. of or relating to dimensions; s. having dimension—the quality or character or stature proper to a person;...
possessive pe'zesɪv POS: n	n. 所有格; a. 所有的, 占有的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. serving to express or indicate possession; s. desirous of owning; s. having or showing a desire to control o...
neglectful ni'glektfʊl POS: a	a. 不小心的, 疏忽的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s not showing due care or attention; s failing in what duty requires